there are a few that score high in storytelling and production capabilities.

There's *The Far Post* by Dur Se Brothers, directed by Yuki Ellias (recipient of best actor at META 2017) that delves into magic realism, mask dance movement and puppetry. Another act that can't be missed is *Afghanistan Is Not Funny*, a docu-play by multi-award-winning playwright Henry Naylor, based on true events in war-torn Afghanistan.

Some other performances include Adishakti's play *Bhoomi*, a loose adaptation of *Bhoomirakshasa* by Malayalam writer Sara Joseph and *Rest of the Story* performed by students of the Department of Theatre, University of Hyderabad.

"We focus on inclusivity in people, diversity in experience and engagement in exchange. Through diverse performances, we are attempting to bridge the gap between veterans and students. That's the kind of communication and empowerment we are aiming for," reiterates Vedula.

Going forward, the idea is to also break barriers in language by including more regional voices, apart from English, Hindi and Telugu that are already a part of the inaugural edition. "Our vision is to be an annual festival, if not more often. Now that we have a format and understanding of the values of the festival, it will be ideal to establish it as a property and then travel to other parts of the country in the future," says Vedula. ■

Geetika Sachdev

MUSIC

BOYISH MAN

Irish singer and former Boyzone vocalist Ronan Keating is on a whirlwind India tour this month

It's a great year for Indian fans of 1990s boy bands. After the Backstreet Boys performed here in May, Ronan Keating will stage a three-city tour this month (November 17-19), just a week before fellow Irish chart-toppers Westlife visit.

Keating, who became a household name as a member of Boyzone and forged a successful solo career thereafter, is proof that acts that are often dismissed as bubblegum can last much longer than critics predicted. "For me, I think the greatest achievement is longevity," says the singer who celebrates 30 years as a professional artist this year. "I think in the '90s, there was a lot of stigma attached to boy bands, especially when we were up against Oasis and Blur, and all of these bands that were trying to be credible. [But] we were having a great time, we were living the dream, I have continued to."

He attributes the enduring appeal of '90s-era pop to the very aspect for which the style is often derided: its simplicity. "There's a [strong] love for music that is not complicated. It's about taking people away from all the troubles and everything that's going on in the world because the world is complicated. My music is all about feeling good, so I hope that everybody who comes to the shows goes away feeling that there was a warmth."

Fans in Mumbai, where he will perform at the Phoenix Marketcity mall, and in Bengaluru and Shillong, where he will headline the Tape Deck and Cherry Blossom festivals, respectively, will be pleased to read that Keating plans to deliver only the hits. "Everything on the set list has been a top 10," says the 46-year-old who, with Boyzone and on his own, has scored more than 30 such smashes in the UK. These include several covers such as Cat Stevens's 'Father and Son', Billy Ocean's 'When the Going Gets Tough', Garth Brooks's 'If Tomorrow Never Comes', and what's arguably his most popular tune, 'When You Say Nothing at All' from the soundtrack of the rom-com classic *Notting Hill*.

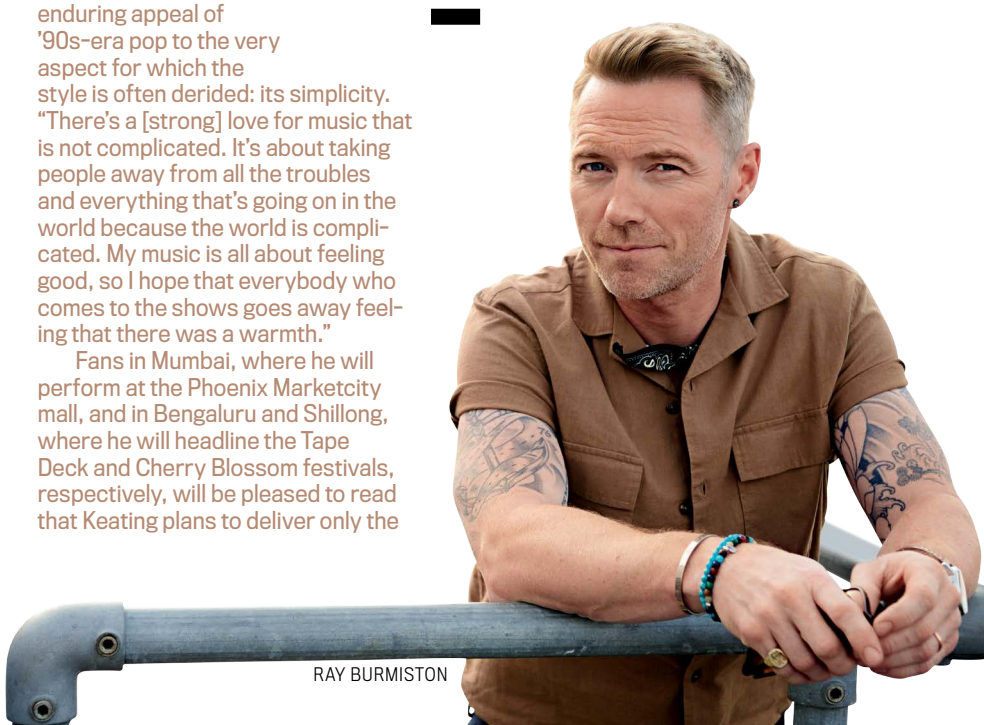
Yet, even though he's been singing these songs for decades, Keating tells INDIA TODAY that he never tires of rendering them. "I feel blessed that I'm still doing it," he says. "Connecting with the audience is an electric feeling." Another thing he doesn't take for granted is that he's managed to remain on people's radar at a time when even the proverbial 15 minutes of fame has been reduced to 15 seconds.

Keating has stayed in the news thanks to his stints as a judge and coach on reality TV singing talent competition series like *The X Factor* and *The Voice* and as a presenter on the live BBC TV programme *The One Show*. "Unless you're Ed Sheeran or Adele, it's harder now to be in the public eye all the time," says Keating. "So you've got to find ways to stay relevant. It takes a lot of work, a lot of commitment, but it definitely helps and works." ■

Amit Gurbaxani

> ***Ronan Keating*** attributes the enduring appeal of '90s-era pop to the very aspect for which the style is often derided: its simplicity

Keating will perform in Mumbai on Nov. 17, Bengaluru on Nov. 18 and Shillong on Nov. 19.



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